

RAILWAYS, TELECOM & IT
ENGINES OF THE ECONOMY

ON THE FAST TRACK

The government's relentless focus on ensuring the seamless progress of initiatives in these realms has become a key factor in shaping India's growth story

At a time when the Indian Railways has got double the capital budget outlay and other sectors such as telecom and information technology are making rapid strides, playing a critical role in India's growth story, Union minister for railways, communications, electronics & information technology **Ashwini Vaishnaw** lists out the achievements of the departments under him and spells out his priorities.

LENGTHENING THE TRACKS

Our economy is growing at about 6- per cent. This means that the demand for logistics also is growing at a pace that is faster than this. If we were to depend only on roads, imagine how much more pollution and how much more oil requirement there will be. So, that's why our Prime Minister Narendra Modiji is executing a very well-thought-through strategy. In the past nine and a half years, 40,000 km of railway tracks have been electrified. Now, the focus is on laying more tracks. So, in the same period, we have laid about 25,000 km of tracks. Last year itself, we laid about 5,200 km of tracks.

PUSH FOR CARGO MOVEMENT

Our target is 35 per cent by 2030. And with that, our dependence on oil imports should significantly reduce, and over a period of, let's say from 2030 to 2047, we should do about 55 per cent of the cargo by rail.

FAST PACE OF BULLET TRAIN!

We have already constructed about 235 km of it, and it's going on very well. Recently, the Japanese PM sent a special delegation to see how India is progressing so fast. There are industries from Rajkot, Vadodara that have become exporters of the technology.

EXPANDING THE NETWORK

The way Shri Atalji did four-laning of highways...exactly in the same way, Modiji is four-laning some places and six-laning most of the large railway sections.

THE SELF-RELIANCE MODE

Our PM has very categorically mandated that in every important technology, we have to become *aatmanirbhar*. Railways, telecom, digital, practically every large, complex technology...some of these technologies we have not only mastered, but have also started exporting. Today, Made in India (telecom) equipment is getting exported to 40-plus countries.... Our Vande Bharat trains have helped us master five key technologies, which position us to be able to design the bullet trains.

UPGRADE OF RAILWAYS

Our coach production, our locomotive production, our wagon production, everything is almost multiplied.... What has really gone in is huge investment in safety.... The number of accidents during 2004-14 used to be about 170 a year. That number has now drastically come down to about 45 accidents a year. In Modiji's third term, you will see a large capacity increase in Railways, you will see a huge